

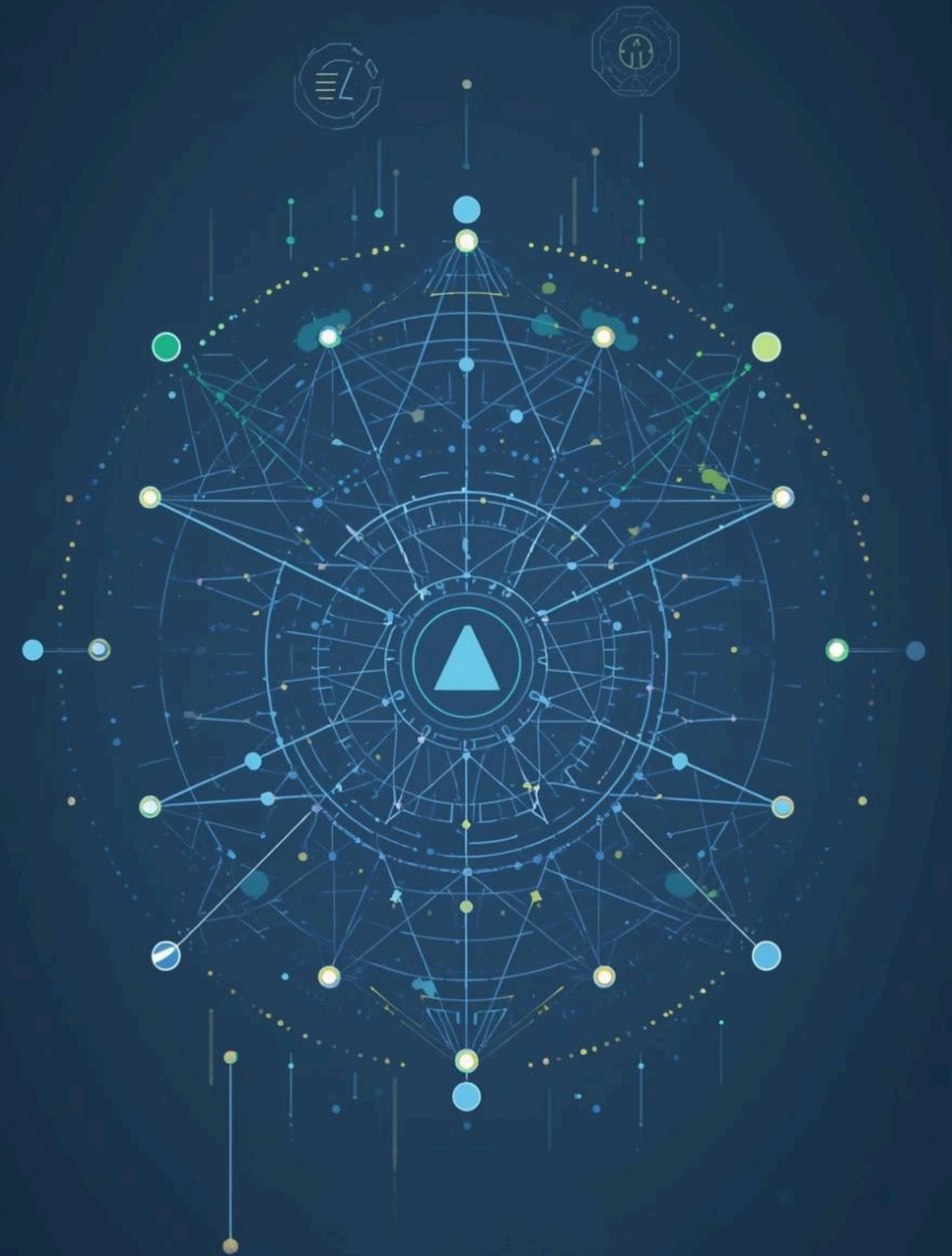
Ethical Decision-Making Frameworks



How it Happens

Most ethical failures are not caused by evil intent but rather:

- Time pressure
- Organizational incentives
- Ambiguous responsibility
- Groupthink
- "Everyone else is doing it"



A Practical 6-Step Ethical Decision Framework

Step 1 - Define the Problem Clearly

- What exactly is being built or deployed?
- What could go wrong?
- Who might be affected?

Avoid vague language.



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Step 2 - Identify Stakeholders

Who is impacted?

- End users
- Non-users indirectly affected
- Vulnerable populations
- Regulators
- Employees
- Society at large

Ethical blind spots often occur because unseen stakeholders are ignored.

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Step 3 - Apply Multiple Ethical Lenses

Try to apply:

- Consequentialist analysis → What are likely outcomes?
- Deontological analysis → Are rights being violated?
- Virtue ethics → What kind of organization/person are we becoming?
- Justice/fairness analysis → Who bears the burden?

If conclusions conflict, the tension reveals the ethical core.

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Step 4 - Evaluate Harm Severity & Reversibility

Ask:

- Is harm reversible?
- Is it systemic or isolated?
- Is it scalable?
- Is it irreversible?

High-scale + irreversible harm demands stronger safeguards.



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Step 5 - Consider Legal and Regulatory Constraints

Ethics $\neq$ law.

But law sets minimum thresholds.

Ask:

- Are there compliance obligations?
- Are emerging regulations relevant?

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Step 6 — Decide and Document

Documentation matters:

- What risks were identified?
- What mitigation was implemented?
- Who approved?

This protects both the organization and the individual professional.

Key Message

Ethical reasoning must be repeatable and structured, not intuitive and reactive.

